

THE UTILITY OF GOOGLE SEARCH TRENDS

Google search trends are a useful indicator of what is grabbing mainstream attention. The innovative investor can go to <https://trends.google.com/> and explore the patterns of how people are searching for different topics. Google even provides the option to explore search trends by geographical location, giving charts of where interest is spiking, as well as showing what related topics are on the rise. For example, after typing in “bitcoin,” investors can look at Google search trends for the last year, or five years, or a custom range, and investigate how Nigeria differs from India. We recommend orienting with this tool even beyond cryptoassets, as it’s a fascinating window into the global mesh of minds.

At this point, bitcoin’s spike captured the attention of the People’s Bank of China, which promptly implemented restrictions on bitcoin’s use, declaring it was “not a currency in the real meaning of the word.”⁵ The China ruling, combined with the FBI’s capture of the creator of the Silk Road, Ross Ulbricht,⁶ and soon thereafter the collapse of the biggest exchange at the time, Mt. Gox,⁷ put many bitcoin investors on edge as to its long-term viability in the face of government and law enforcement crackdowns.⁸ Bitcoin’s subsequent price descent through all of 2014, bottoming in January 2015, was volatile, prolonged, and dispiriting for many early adopters who had been drawn to the new concept.